

Conformations Search methods for molecular docking

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1 Basic concepts in conformational search

Understanding molecular conformation the three-dimensional arrangement of atoms in a molecule is fundamental to computational chemistry. A molecule's conformation determines its chemical and biological properties, including reactivity, solubility, and binding affinity to biological targets. In the context of this book, this conformational search is performed within the binding site of receptor, which aims to locate the bioactive conformation. Unlike global or local minimum conformation in solution, bioactive conformation is one of the low energy conformations that shows most appropriate shape complementary with the binding site. This maximises favourable interactions between the ligand and receptor atoms. The success of structure-based drug design methods depends on identifying this bioactive conformation.

A typical small drug-like molecule may contain multiple rotatable bonds, each capable of adopting several energetically distinct rotameric states. With n rotatable bonds and approximately 3 accessible rotameric states per bond, the conformational space contains roughly 3^n distinct conformations. For a molecule with 12 rotatable bonds typical for many pharmaceutically relevant compounds, this yields nearly 530,000 possible conformations. Manual identification becomes impractical, necessitating automated conformational search methods.

1.1 Potential Energy Surface

The PES describes the relationship between molecular geometry (represented by $3N-6$ degrees of freedom for N atoms in three dimensions) and electronic energy. Formally, for a molecule in a given electronic state, the PES is a

multidimensional function $E(\mathbf{R})$ where $\mathbf{R}$ represents all atomic coordinates. A conformation corresponds to a local minimum on the PES:

$$\nabla E(\mathbf{R}) = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \nabla^2 E(\mathbf{R}) \text{ is positive definite} \quad (1)$$

where ∇ is the gradient operator and ∇^2 is the Hessian matrix. The global minimum is the conformation with the lowest energy across all conformational space, while important local minima separated by accessible energy barriers represent alternative conformations accessible at finite temperature.

1.2 Rotatable Bonds and Dihedral Angles

Conformational diversity arises primarily from rotation around single bonds. A dihedral angle (or torsion angle) ϕ describes the spatial relationship between four atoms: the angle between the planes defined by atoms (1-2-3) and (2-3-4). The dihedral angle potential energy can be approximated by a periodic function:

$$V_{\text{torsion}}(\phi) = \sum_{n=1}^3 \frac{V_n}{2} [1 + \cos(n\phi - \gamma_n)] \quad (2)$$

where V_n are force constants and γ_n are phase angles specific to the bond type. This expression shows that rotation about a bond encounters periodic energy minima, typically 3 per 360° rotation (corresponding to staggered conformations in ethane-like systems).

1.3 Energy-Based Metrics

Key metrics characterize conformational search results:

$$\Delta E = E_{\text{conformer}} - E_{\text{global minimum}} \quad (3)$$

The relative energy ΔE expresses each conformation's energy relative to the lowest-energy structure. The Boltzmann population at temperature T predicts the probability of observing a particular conformation:

$$P_i = \frac{e^{-\Delta E_i/k_B T}}{\sum_j e^{-\Delta E_j/k_B T}} \quad (4)$$

where k_B is Boltzmann's constant (1.987 cal·mol⁻¹·K⁻¹). At 298 K, conformations within 2 kcal/mol of the global minimum constitute > 10% of the population and should be included in conformational ensembles.

The RMSD quantifies geometric similarity between two conformations:

$$\text{RMSD} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N d_i^2} \quad (5)$$

where d_i represents the distance between atoms i after optimal superposition. RMSD thresholds (typically 1.0–2.0 Å) filter redundant conformations in search output.

2 Conformational search methods

One of the most challenging aspect of pose prediction is the conformational search algorithm. In general, there are two main classes of conformational search methods, systematic and stochastic. The users do not always have a choice to select the search algorithm because the developers usually select based on their expertise and code development. Nevertheless, there are programs, such as AutoDock, that allow users to select the search algorithm.

2.1 Systematic Methods

The systematic search algorithm rotates all possible rotatable bonds (single bonds in the ring structures cannot be rotated as freely as open-chain structures) systematically by a fixed interval to explore all possible conformations. Such a method can explore all possible conformations, however, the complexity increases exponentially as the number of rotatable bonds increases. There are pruning algorithms that act as a “bump check” that rule out torsion angles that lead to significant atomic overlaps. The deterministic nature of systematic sampling guarantees that the same input will yield the same set of conformers, which is advantageous for benchmarking and reproducibility. However, the combinatorial explosion of grid points with increasing rotatable bonds quickly becomes prohibitive, especially for highly flexible ligands, motivating the use of hybrid schemes or coarse-grained grids in practice[1].

2.1.1 Grid-based enumeration

The simplest systematic approach divides torsion angle space into discrete intervals (e.g., 10° or 30°) and evaluates all possible combinations. For a molecule with n rotatable bonds and 36 intervals per 360° rotation:

$$N_{\text{conformations}} = 36^n \quad (6)$$

This method guarantees finding the global minimum but becomes computationally prohibitive for large n (combinatorial explosion). Grid enumeration works well for rigid molecules with 2–4 rotatable bonds but is impractical for flexible compounds.

In the context of molecular docking, the search space is limited to the binding pocket, often provided as a grid. Therefore, the systematic conformational search engine operates by discretizing the relevant degrees of freedom typically torsional angles on a this grid. It then generated and evaluates all combinations of torsion angles within that grid. For a molecule with n rotatable bonds, each torsion is sampled at a fixed interval, producing a Cartesian product of values $\phi_1 \in \phi_1^{(1)}, \dots, \phi_1^{(k)}, \phi_2 \in \phi_2^{(1)}, \dots, \phi_2^{(k)}$ and so on. At each grid point, the geometry is energy-minimized, and the resulting conformers are clustered and ranked by energy or empirical scoring functions. Because the search is exhaustive within the chosen resolution, systematic methods can in principle locate all sterically allowed conformations of a given molecule, provided the grid is sufficiently fine and the force field adequately describes the intramolecular energetics[2].

2.1.2 The Z method

The Z method[3] is a variant of grid-based conformational search protocols that employs statistical information on the rotamers. It partitions the conformational space into subspaces and then applies repeated, uniform changes to a common starting structure, generating large ensembles of trial conformations in parallel. This approach allows rigid systematic searches in high dimensional spaces by combining grid-based sampling with statistical information from rotamer libraries. The Z Method can also be used hierarchically: low resolution searches identify approximate regions of interest, which are then refined with finer grids or energy minimization protocols. The key advantage is the ability to couple systematic search with probabilistic rotamer preferences, improving the sampling efficiency while preserving the exhaustiveness of the underlying grid. However, to the best of our knowledge, this method has only been applied protein structure refinement. We did not find any literature references indicating its use as conformational search tool for small molecules or in molecular docking.

2.2 Fragmentation method

In this method, the molecule is broken down into individual fragments. The fragments are then docked in the most suitable sub-pocket in the binding site. The entire molecule is then sequentially built by adding the linkers. This fol-

allows a systematic search for the linker conformation that optimally holds the fragments in their respective sub-pockets. The fragmentation method selects the rigid molecular components, for example ring structures, as fragments, and the flexible components as linkers. In doing so, this method reduces the computational complexity compared to the systematic search by focusing on small components, more particularly the linkers. FlexX and DOCK are examples of the docking algorithms that employ this method as its conformational search algorithm.

2.3 Stochastic Methods

Stochastic techniques utilize random sampling and probabilistic methods to explore the conformational space. They work by randomly making changes, preferably, to the rotatable bonds and evaluates the energy following the change. Metropolis Monte Carlo, and Genetic algorithm are popular stochastic search methods that are used as conformational search tools in docking programs.

2.3.1 Monte Carlo

It works on the principle of random sampling for a predetermined number of iterations to locate optimum conformation. The search algorithm starts by making a random changes in any of randomly selected rotatable bond. Following which, it evaluates the energy and compares it with the starting conformation. If the energy of the new state is lower than the previous state, then the conformation is accepted. If the energy of the new state is higher than the previous state, then it assigns a random number between 0 and 1 and evaluates its probability against the Boltzmann distribution; if the random number assigned is greater than the probability, then the new state is accepted otherwise rejected. In case of the rejection, the algorithm restarts from the previous conformations. Glide docking program is also known to employ Monte Carlo simulation in its docking algorithm to improve its pose prediction accuracy.

2.3.2 Genetic Algorithm (GA)

This method is motivated from the process of natural selection, that evaluates energy or docking score as the fitness criteria for selection and breeding. Akin to natural selection, the conformational degrees of freedom are encoded as binary numbers which represents specify values of the torsion angles. At the beginning, several random mutations are made in the binary numbers

(interchanging “0” to “1”) and generating an initial population. The fitness score is evaluated for each member. Following which the top ranked (fittest members) are retained for breeding. To generate future generations, either cross-over is performed or mutations. This process is repeated for a pre-determined number of iterations. Autodock and GOLD are examples of docking programs that use genetic algorithm as their conformational search tool.

2.4 Molecular Dynamics Simulations

At this point, it is appropriate to gently introduce another powerful conformational search method, namely *molecular dynamics (MD) simulations*. It simulates the atomic motions as a function of time by solving the Newton’s equation of motion. MD simulations and molecular docking are complementary that are commonly employed in structure-based drug discovery to understand the protein-ligand interactions and their dynamics aspects. For computational efficiency, molecular docking algorithms treat receptors atoms rigid and the ligand as flexible. This leads to incorrect pose prediction when induced fit binding is observed. Therefore, MD simulation is an elegant method to incorporate such induced fit effects. This can be achieved in two ways, as shown below:

- Pre-docking step to sample various conformations of the receptor without the influence of the ligand. This can serve as multiple receptor conformations for docking.
- Post-docking step to refine the docked receptor-ligand conformation by allowing the complex to evolve to their realistic conformation, which would be more probable physiologically.

2.5 Simulated Annealing

Simulated annealing (SA) is a powerful stochastic optimization technique widely used in conformational search for molecular docking, where the goal is to locate low-energy ligand and protein conformations compatible with experimental binding modes. In SA, the system is first “heated” to a high virtual temperature, allowing large, energetically unfavorable moves that overcome local minima, and then gradually cooled so that the trajectory converges toward deep basins of the potential energy landscape. This mapping of thermodynamic annealing onto conformational space makes SA particularly suited to global-optimization problems such as flexible-ligand docking, where the search space is rugged and high-dimensional.

1. *Heating phase*: Starting from an initial conformation, the system is rapidly heated to high temperature (typically 800–1000 K), providing energy to overcome conformational barriers.
2. *Annealing phase*: Temperature is gradually reduced according to a cooling schedule, allowing the system to explore broader conformational space while progressively favoring lower-energy structures.
3. *Minimization phase*: At low temperature (50–100 K), geometry optimization drives the system to a nearby local minimum.

The SA protocol may be repeated 100+ times from different initial conformations, generating diverse low-energy structures. Effectiveness depends critically on cooling rate: too rapid cooling traps the system in local minima; too slow cooling demands excessive computation.

2.6 Distance Geometry Methods

2.7 Hybrid systematic–stochastic schemes

3 Practical Considerations

3.1 Handling Ring Systems

Acyclic molecules with many rotatable bonds dominate conformational search applications. Ring systems pose special challenges: ring conformations (chair, twist, boat forms for cyclohexane; envelope conformations for five-membered rings) must be explicitly sampled. Most tools handle six-membered rings well; smaller rings and fused ring systems require careful validation.

3.2 Accounting for solvation effects

Bioactive conformations depend on the solvent environment. Implicit solvation models (Generalized Born, Poisson-Boltzmann) add solvation energy terms, affecting the conformational landscape relative to gas-phase calculations.

3.3 Clustering of Results

Why we need clustering? and how does this ensure use diverse conformations for next step.

RMSD:

$$\text{RMSD} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum_i |\mathbf{r}_i - \mathbf{r}'_i|^2}$$

Clusters identify recurring poses.

3.4 Validation Metrics

Conformational search quality is evaluated by:

1. **Recovery of Crystallographic Conformations:** For validation datasets with known bioactive structures (e.g., protein-bound ligand conformations), the minimum RMSD from the ensemble to experimental structure indicates success. Recovery within 2 Å RMSD is considered good.
2. **Conformational Diversity:** The range of geometries in the final ensemble should comprehensively represent the conformational space. Metrics include distribution of dihedral angles and range of relative energies.
3. **Computational Efficiency:** Wall-clock time and peak memory usage relative to molecular size determine practical viability. For drug discovery pipelines screening millions of compounds, efficiency is paramount.

4 Summary

Conformational search is the computational engine that enables docking. Understanding both the physics of the scoring function and the algorithms used to explore conformational space is essential for reliable predictions. Hybrid strategies that combine stochastic global exploration with local refinement currently offer the best trade-off between efficiency and accuracy.

References

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